

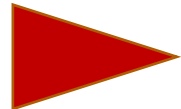
Psychological Aspects, Motivation, Barriers to Civic Engagement and Introduction to SDGs

Week 3

Rabia Zia

rabia.zia@nu.edu.pk





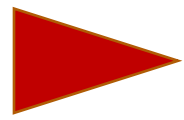
1. Psychological Aspects of Civic Engagement

- Civic engagement is a fundamental component of a functioning democracy. It includes a wide range of activities that allow citizens to participate in the decision-making processes that affect their lives.
- The psychological aspects of civic engagement include the **motivations, barriers, emotional influences, and cognitive processes** that drive individuals to become active citizens.
- These psychological factors are crucial in understanding why people choose to engage—or disengage—from civic activities, and they play a significant role in shaping the effectiveness and inclusivity of civic participation.



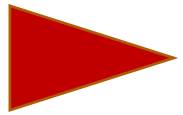
a. Social Identity

- One of the key psychological factors influencing civic engagement is the concept of social identity.
- **Social identity theory**, which explores how an individuals' self-concepts are shaped by their membership in social groups, is a fundamental psychological aspect of civic engagement.
- People are more likely to engage in civic activities when they identify strongly with a community or cause. This identification fosters a sense of belonging and a shared purpose, which in turn motivates individuals to take actions that benefit the group.
- For instance, members of a marginalized community may be more inclined to participate in advocacy and protest activities aimed at addressing issues that affect their group directly. The strength of this identification can influence the intensity and consistency of engagement, making social identity a powerful driver of civic participation.



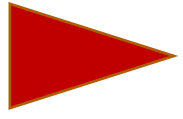
b. The Role of Perceived Efficacy

- Perceived efficacy, or the belief that one's actions can lead to meaningful change, is another critical psychological factor in civic engagement. This concept is divided into two key components: **self-efficacy** and **collective efficacy**.
- **Self-efficacy** refers to an individual's belief in their ability to perform actions that contribute to civic outcomes, such as organizing a community event or speaking at a public meeting.
- **Collective efficacy**, on the other hand, is the belief in the power of group efforts to effect change.
- Both forms of efficacy are essential for sustaining civic engagement, as they foster a sense of empowerment. When individuals believe that their actions, whether alone or in concert with others, can make a difference, they are more likely to participate actively in civic life.
- However, a lack of perceived efficacy can lead to disengagement. Individuals who feel powerless or believe that their contributions will not have a significant impact may withdraw from civic activities, leading to apathy and a decline in participation. This is particularly prevalent in communities that have historically been marginalized or have faced systemic barriers to influence, where skepticism about the potential for change can be deeply ingrained.



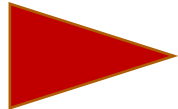
c. Emotional Drivers of Civic Engagement

- Emotions play an important role in motivating civic engagement, with different emotions driving various forms of participation.
- **Empathy** is a powerful motivator that compels individuals to act on behalf of others. Empathic concern for those who are suffering or disadvantaged can lead to **volunteering, charitable donations, and other forms of selfless behavior**. This is often observed in community service initiatives where the emotional connection to the cause—such as helping the homeless or supporting victims of natural disasters—drives sustained involvement.



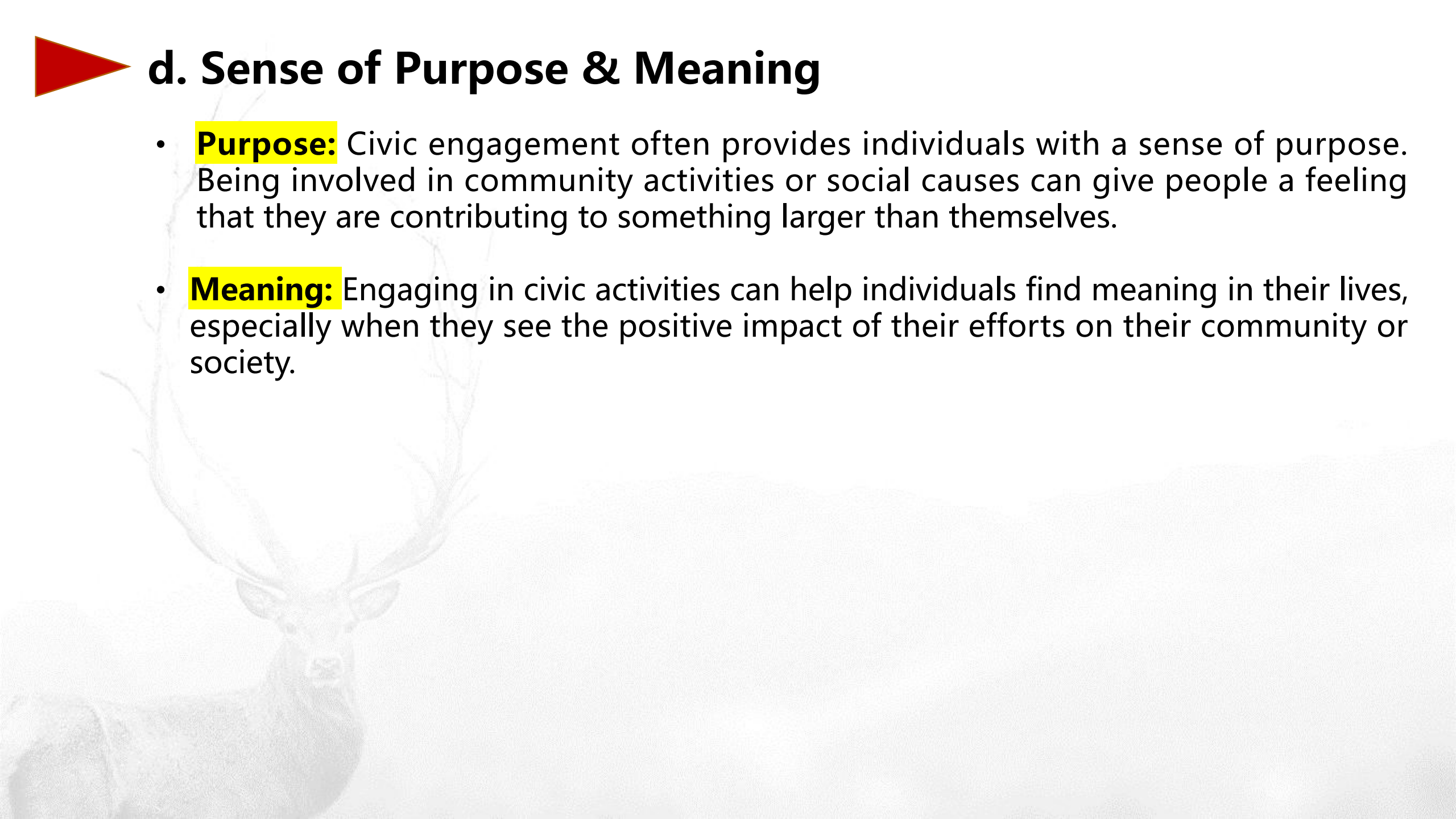
c. Emotional Drivers of Civic Engagement

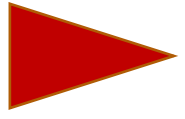
- **Anger** is another emotion that can spur civic action, particularly in response to perceived injustices.
- This emotion is often linked to protest and activism, where individuals channel their anger into efforts to challenge the status quo and demand change. The civil rights movements across the globe, for example, were significantly fueled by collective anger against systemic racism and inequality.
- While anger can be a powerful catalyst for engagement, it can also lead to polarization and conflict if not managed constructively.
- **Hope and optimism** are also critical emotional drivers, providing the motivation for long-term engagement. These emotions sustain participation even in the face of setbacks, as they build a belief in the possibility of positive change.
- Hopeful individuals are more likely to invest their time and energy in civic activities because they see the potential for a better future.
- This is particularly evident in movements focused on social and environmental justice, where hope for a sustainable and equitable world drives continued advocacy and action.



d. Sense of Purpose & Meaning

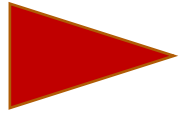
- **Purpose:** Civic engagement often provides individuals with a sense of purpose. Being involved in community activities or social causes can give people a feeling that they are contributing to something larger than themselves.
- **Meaning:** Engaging in civic activities can help individuals find meaning in their lives, especially when they see the positive impact of their efforts on their community or society.





e. Learned Helplessness, Political Apathy & Burnout

- If people believe their actions won't make a difference, they disengage (e.g., low voter turnout in corrupt political systems).
- Previous failures in activism (e.g., failed protests) can reduce motivation to engage again.
- People justify inaction by convincing themselves civic engagement is unnecessary or ineffective (e.g., "Someone else will fix the problem").
- Activist fatigue occurs when individuals engage too much without seeing immediate results, leading to withdrawal.
- Too much information (information overload) can lead to inaction instead of engagement.



2. Motivation for Civic Participation

Sense of Duty and Civic Responsibility

- One of the most powerful motivators for civic participation is a sense of duty or moral obligation. Many individuals engage in civic activities because they believe it is their responsibility as citizens to contribute to the well-being of their community or nation. This sense of duty is often instilled through socialization processes, including family upbringing, education, and cultural norms. In many societies, civic duties such as voting, paying taxes, and participating in community service are seen as essential aspects of citizenship.
- For example, in democratic countries, the act of voting is not only a right but also a civic duty that individuals feel compelled to fulfill, as it represents their contribution to the democratic process.
- This sense of civic responsibility is further reinforced by the belief that participation is necessary for the proper functioning of society. Individuals who are motivated by a sense of duty often perceive their involvement as vital to maintaining social order and promoting the common good.
- This motivation is particularly strong in communities with a high degree of social cohesion, where collective norms and values emphasize the importance of contributing to the community. For example, during times of crisis, such as natural disasters or public health emergencies, the sense of duty can drive individuals to volunteer, donate resources, or participate in relief efforts, reflecting their commitment to supporting their community.

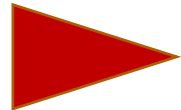


a. Desire for Social Change

- Individuals who are driven by a commitment to addressing societal issues, such as inequality, injustice, or environmental degradation, are often motivated to engage in civic activities to advocate for change. This motivation is deeply rooted in personal values and beliefs about what is just and right. For example, individuals who are passionate about environmental conservation may participate in activities such as tree planting, recycling initiatives, or climate advocacy to contribute to the fight against climate change.
- The desire for social change is also closely linked to the concept of social justice. Individuals who perceive that certain groups are marginalized or disadvantaged are often motivated to take action to address these disparities. This can include participating in advocacy efforts, supporting social movements, or volunteering with organizations that work towards social justice goals. For instance, the civil rights movement in the United States was largely driven by individuals motivated by a desire to end racial discrimination and achieve equality. This commitment to social change often transcends personal interests, as individuals are motivated by a broader vision of creating a more just and equitable society.
- Furthermore, the desire for social change is not limited to addressing large-scale societal issues. It can also manifest in efforts to improve local communities, such as advocating for better public services, supporting local businesses, or participating in neighborhood clean-up initiatives. In these cases, the motivation is often driven by a sense of ownership and pride in one's community, as individuals seek to create positive change in their immediate surroundings.

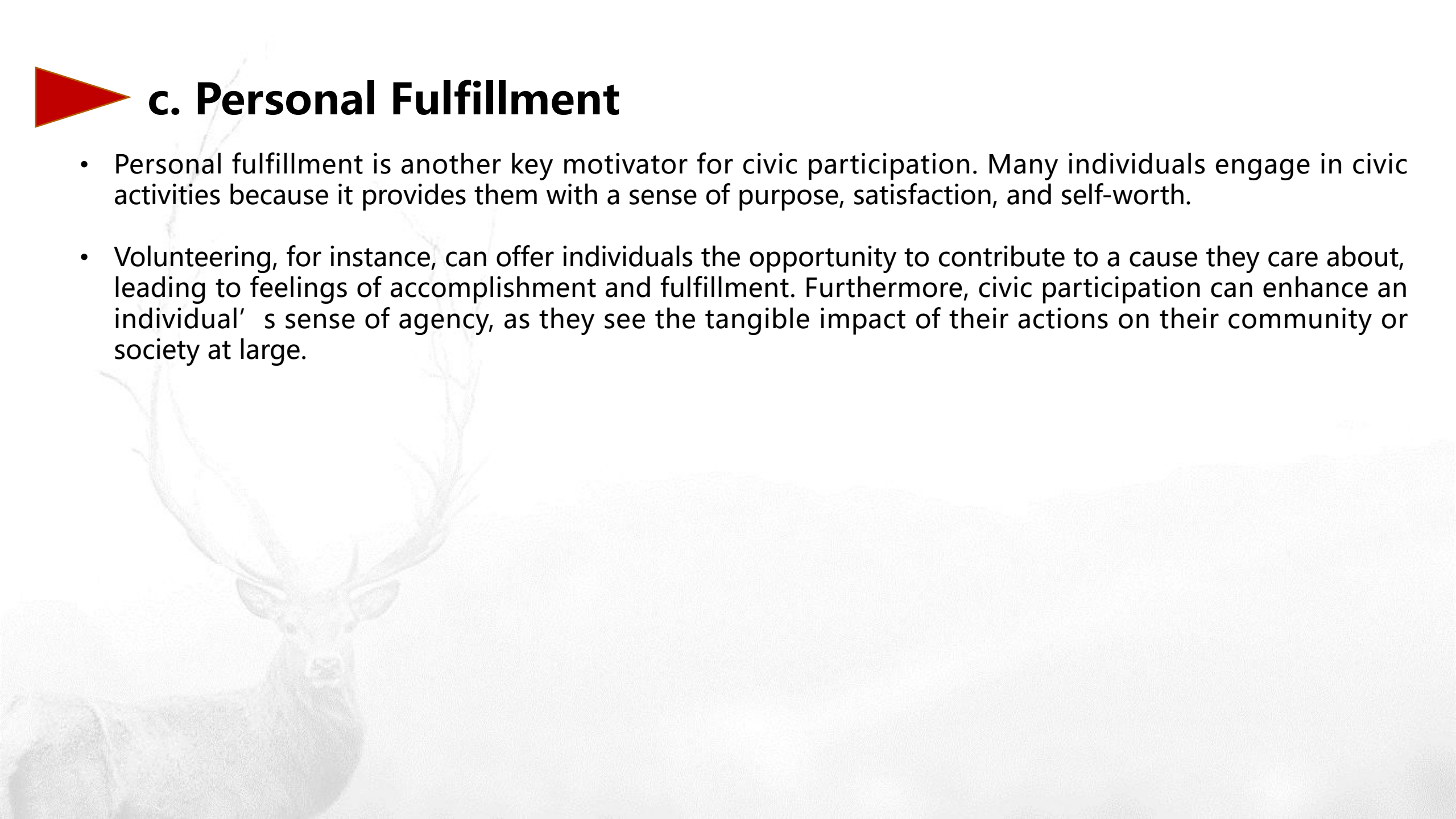
b. Social Connectedness and Community Engagement

- Individuals are more likely to engage in civic activities when they feel a sense of belonging and connection to their community. This motivation is rooted in the human need for social interaction and the desire to be part of something larger than oneself. People who have strong social ties are often more engaged in their communities, as these connections provide both the emotional support and the practical opportunities needed to participate in civic life.
- Community networks play a vital role in fostering civic engagement by providing information, resources, and encouragement. Social networks can facilitate civic participation by connecting individuals with opportunities to get involved, such as volunteer events, community meetings, or local advocacy efforts. Additionally, the presence of role models within these networks—such as family members, friends, or community leaders who are actively engaged in civic activities—can inspire others to participate. For example, individuals who see their peers volunteering at a local food bank or attending a town hall meeting may be more inclined to do the same, motivated by the desire to be part of a collective effort.
- Moreover, social connectedness can enhance the sense of efficacy and impact of civic participation. When individuals feel supported by their community, they are more likely to believe that their actions can make a difference. This collective efficacy reinforces the motivation to engage, as individuals perceive their participation as contributing to a larger, shared goal. For instance, in community-based initiatives such as neighborhood watch programs or local environmental projects, the sense of working together towards a common objective can be a powerful motivator for sustained engagement.



c. Personal Fulfillment

- Personal fulfillment is another key motivator for civic participation. Many individuals engage in civic activities because it provides them with a sense of purpose, satisfaction, and self-worth.
- Volunteering, for instance, can offer individuals the opportunity to contribute to a cause they care about, leading to feelings of accomplishment and fulfillment. Furthermore, civic participation can enhance an individual's sense of agency, as they see the tangible impact of their actions on their community or society at large.



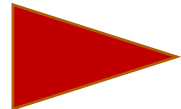


3. Barriers to Civic Engagement

- Various barriers can impede individuals from becoming actively involved in civic activities, ranging from structural and institutional obstacles to personal and psychological challenges.
- One of the most significant barriers to civic engagement is **socio-economic inequality**. Individuals from disadvantaged socio-economic backgrounds often face greater challenges in accessing opportunities for civic participation.
- For example, low-income individuals may lack the time, resources, or transportation needed to attend community meetings, volunteer, or participate in protests.
- Additionally, socio-economic inequalities can lead to a sense of disenfranchisement, where individuals feel that their voices are not heard or valued in the decision-making process, leading to disengagement.

3. Barriers to Civic Engagement Contd..

- Another major barrier is **political disenchantment or distrust**. In many societies, individuals may become disillusioned with the political system, believing that it is corrupt, unresponsive, or dominated by elites who do not represent their interests.
- This sense of political disillusionment can lead to apathy and a lack of motivation to engage in civic activities, as individuals may feel that their participation will not make a difference. The erosion of trust in political institutions and leaders is a significant challenge to fostering active civic engagement.
- **Cultural and social factors** also play a role in limiting civic engagement. In some communities, cultural norms and expectations may discourage certain groups, such as women or minorities, from participating in public life.
- For instance, in patriarchal societies, women may face social stigma or resistance when trying to engage in civic activities, such as running for office or leading community initiatives. Similarly, ethnic or religious minorities may encounter discrimination or exclusion, which can hinder their participation in civic life.



3. Barriers to Civic Engagement Contd..

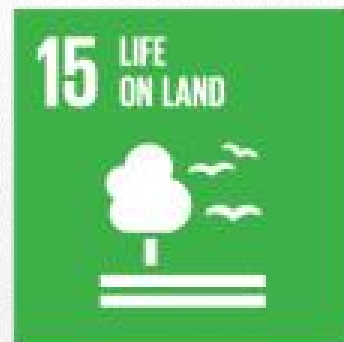
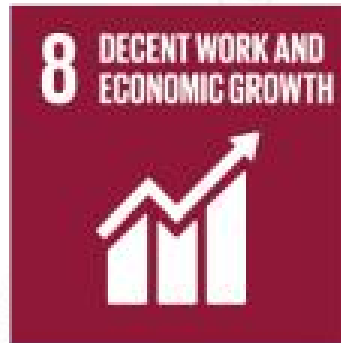
- **Technological barriers** are increasingly relevant in the digital age. While digital platforms offer new opportunities for civic engagement, they also present challenges, particularly for those who lack access to technology or the skills to use it effectively.
- The digital divide, which refers to the gap between those who have access to digital technologies and those who do not, can worsen existing inequalities in civic participation. Additionally, online civic engagement can sometimes be hindered by issues such as misinformation, cyberbullying, or the overwhelming nature of digital content.

Sustainable Development Goals

- The Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) are a set of 17 global goals adopted by the United Nations (UN) in 2015 as part of the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development. These goals aim to address social, economic, and environmental challenges to create a more equitable and sustainable world.
- **Key Features of SDGs**
 - **Universal** – Apply to all countries, both developed and developing.
 - **Interconnected** – Progress in one goal impacts others (e.g., education improves economic growth).
 - **Aim** - End poverty, protect the planet, and ensure peace & prosperity by 2030
 - **Time-Bound** – Target year for achievement is 2030.



SUSTAINABLE DEVELOPMENT GOALS





**End Poverty
in All its
Forms
Everywhere**

Goal 1: No Poverty

End Poverty in All Forms Everywhere



Global Poverty Challenge

Over 700 million people still live in extreme poverty, earning less than \$2.15 per day.



Objective

Eradicate extreme poverty for all people everywhere by 2030, ensuring equal access to resources and services.



Key Strategies

Expand social protection systems, ensure equal economic opportunities, and improve access to essential services.



End hunger, achieve food security and improved nutrition and promote sustainable agriculture

Goal 2: Zero Hunger

End Hunger, Achieve Food Security, and Promote Sustainable Agriculture

- **Global Hunger Crisis:** Over 735 million people face chronic hunger, with food insecurity worsening due to climate change and conflict.
- **Objective:** Ensure access to safe, nutritious, and sufficient food for all people by 2030, especially the poor and vulnerable.
- **Key Strategies:** Increase agricultural productivity, promote sustainable food production, and enhance food distribution networks.





**Ensure healthy
lives and promote
well-being for
all at all ages**

Goal 3: Good Health and Well-being

Ensure Healthy Lives and Promote Well-being for All



Global Health Challenges

Despite progress, 5 million children under age 5 die each year, and 1.5 billion people lack access to essential health services.



Objective

Reduce maternal and child mortality, end epidemics, and ensure universal health coverage by 2030.



Key Strategies

Invest in healthcare infrastructure, expand vaccination programs, and address mental health and non-communicable diseases.



Ensure inclusive and equitable quality education and promote lifelong learning opportunities for all

Goal 4: Quality Education

Ensure Inclusive and Equitable Education for All



Education Crisis

244 million children and youth worldwide are out of school, with disparities in literacy rates and educational access.



Objective

Ensure free, equitable, and quality education for all by 2030, including primary, secondary, and vocational training.



Key Strategies

Improve teacher training, expand digital learning, and ensure gender equality in education access.



Achieve gender equality and empower all women and girls

Goal 5: Gender Equality

Achieve Gender Equality and Empower All Women and Girls



Gender Disparities

Women globally earn 20% less than men, and 1 in 3 women experience gender-based violence.



Objective

Eliminate gender discrimination, ensure equal opportunities, and empower women in leadership by 2030.



Key Strategies

Enforce equal pay, combat violence against women, and increase access to education and economic opportunities.



Ensure availability
and sustainable
management of water
and sanitation for all

Goal 6: Clean Water and Sanitation

Ensure Availability and Sustainable Management of Water and Sanitation



Water Crisis

2.2 billion people lack access to safe drinking water, and 3.6 billion lack proper sanitation.



Objective

Provide universal and equitable access to safe and affordable drinking water and sanitation by 2030.



Key Strategies

Improve water infrastructure, promote sustainable water management, and reduce pollution.



Ensure access to
affordable, reliable,
sustainable and
modern energy for all

Goal 7: Affordable and Clean Energy

Ensure Access to Sustainable and Modern Energy for All

- **Energy Access Gap:** 675 million people worldwide lack access to electricity, and 2.3 billion still rely on polluting cooking fuels.
- **Objective:** Ensure universal access to affordable, reliable, and modern energy by 2030, with a focus on renewable sources.
- **Key Strategies:** Expand renewable energy infrastructure, improve energy efficiency, and promote clean technology innovations.





Promote sustained, inclusive and sustainable economic growth, full and productive employment and decent work for all

Goal 8: Decent Work and Economic Growth

Promote Inclusive and Sustainable Economic Growth and Employment

- **Employment Challenges:** Over 200 million people are unemployed globally, and 60% of workers are in informal employment.
- **Objective:** Achieve full and productive employment, ensuring decent work for all, including fair wages and labor rights.
- **Key Strategies:** Boost economic productivity, support entrepreneurship, and enforce labor rights and workplace safety.





Build resilient infrastructure, promote inclusive and sustainable industrialization and foster innovation

Goal 9: Industry, Innovation, and Infrastructure

Build Resilient Infrastructure, Promote Sustainable Industrialization, and Foster Innovation

- **Infrastructure Gaps:** Globally, 940 million people lack access to electricity, and 2.6 billion lack internet access.
- **Objective:** Develop reliable, sustainable, and resilient infrastructure to support economic development and well-being.
- **Key Strategies:** Invest in sustainable transport, expand digital connectivity, and support innovation and industrial growth.





Reduce
inequality
within and
among countries

Goal 10: Reduced Inequalities

Reduce Inequality Within and Among Countries

- **Global Inequality:** The richest 10% earn over 50% of global income, while the poorest 50% receive less than 10%.
- **Objective:** Ensure equal opportunities and reduce income inequality through inclusive policies and social protection systems.
- **Key Strategies:** Promote fair wages, enhance financial inclusion, and eliminate discriminatory laws and practices.





Make cities and human settlements inclusive, safe, resilient and sustainable

Goal 11: Sustainable Cities and Communities

Make Cities Inclusive, Safe, Resilient, and Sustainable



Urbanization Challenges

By 2050, 68% of the global population will live in cities, increasing pressure on housing, infrastructure, and resources.



Objective

Ensure access to affordable housing, improve public transportation, and enhance urban resilience to climate



Key Strategies

Promote smart city planning, increase green spaces, and develop sustainable transportation networks.



Ensure sustainable
consumption
and production
patterns

Goal 12: Responsible Consumption and Production

Ensure Sustainable Consumption and Production Patterns

- **Waste and Overconsumption:** Each year, 931 million tons of food are wasted globally, while resource extraction has tripled since 1970.
- **Objective:** Promote sustainable consumption, reduce waste, and ensure efficient resource use in production and supply chains.
- **Key Strategies:** Encourage circular economies, improve recycling systems, and promote responsible business practices.





Take urgent action
to combat
climate change
and its impacts

Goal 13: Climate Action

Take Urgent Action to Combat Climate Change and Its Impacts

- **Climate Crisis:** Global temperatures have risen by 1.1°C since pre-industrial levels, causing extreme weather events and rising sea levels.
- **Objective:** Reduce greenhouse gas emissions, enhance climate resilience, and integrate climate policies into national strategies.
- **Key Strategies:** Promote renewable energy, improve carbon reduction efforts, and support climate adaptation measures.





Conserve and sustainably use the oceans, seas and marine resources for sustainable development

Goal 14: Life Below Water

Conserve and Sustainably Use the Oceans, Seas, and Marine Resources

- **Marine Degradation:** Over 30% of the world's fish stocks are overexploited, and 8 million tons of plastic enter the ocean each year.
- **Objective:** Protect marine ecosystems, reduce ocean pollution, and promote sustainable fishing practices.
- **Key Strategies:** Reduce plastic waste, establish marine protected areas, and combat ocean acidification.





Protect, restore and promote sustainable use of terrestrial ecosystems, sustainably manage forests, combat desertification and halt and reverse land degradation and halt biodiversity loss

Goal 15: Life on Land

Protect, Restore, and Promote Sustainable Use of Ecosystems



Biodiversity Loss

1 million species are at risk of extinction due to habitat destruction, deforestation, and climate change.



Objective

Ensure conservation of forests, combat desertification, and halt biodiversity loss by 2030.



Key Strategies

Promote reforestation, strengthen wildlife protections, and enforce sustainable land management policies.



Promote peaceful and inclusive societies for sustainable development, provide access to justice for all and build effective, accountable and inclusive institutions at all levels

Goal 16: Peace, Justice, and Strong Institutions

Promote Peaceful and Inclusive Societies

- **Conflict and Instability:** Over 70 million people are forcibly displaced due to violence, corruption, and weak institutions.
- **Objective:** Reduce violence, promote access to justice, and build accountable institutions worldwide.
- **Key Strategies:** Strengthen legal systems, reduce corruption, and promote human rights protections.





Strengthen the means of
implementation and
revitalize the global
partnership for
sustainable development

Goal 17: Partnerships for the Goals

Strengthen Global Partnerships for Sustainable Development

- **Need for Collaboration:** Achieving the SDGs requires global cooperation in finance, technology, trade, and policy-making.
- **Objective:** Enhance international partnerships to mobilize resources, share knowledge, and support sustainable development.
- **Key Strategies:** Increase foreign aid, promote fair trade, and enhance technology transfer to developing countries.



Conclusion: A Call to Action

Building a Sustainable Future Together



The Urgency of Action

Achieving the SDGs by 2030 requires commitment from governments, businesses, and individuals alike.



What You Can Do

Support sustainable initiatives, advocate for policy changes, and adopt eco-friendly habits in daily life.



A Shared Responsibility

Collaboration across nations, industries, and communities is essential for meaningful progress.

